



DECISIVE MOMENT

BATTLE OF LEGNANO

The Battle of Legnano, on May 29, 1176, marked the point at which the city-states of northern Italy gained autonomy from the Holy Roman Emperor, Frederick Barbarossa. A group of these towns, called the Lombard League, objected to the emperor's interference in their internal affairs and, supported by Pope Alexander III, rebelled. The emperor looked sure to triumph when he laid waste the city of Milan. However, the Lombard League defeated his armies at Legnano, northwest of Milan, and he was forced to make peace.



when using silver coins. They also invented the modern financial practices of accounting and insurance to keep track of complicated transactions and prepare for losses due to shipwrecks.

Great trading networks

In northern Europe, the Flanders region grew rich and powerful during the 13th century. Like Italy, its geographical location was key to its development. It straddled an area of modern Belgium and the Netherlands that meant it was ideally positioned to benefit from trade with France, England, and the Holy Roman Empire.

Flanders was ruled by the counts of Flanders and Hainault, who encouraged trade by giving generous privileges to manufacturers. Huge annual fairs took place in the Flemish towns of Lille and Antwerp and farther south in the Champagne region of France. Here, Flemish merchants could sell the cloth that Flanders was famous for producing.

The three main cities of Flanders were Ghent, Bruges, and Ypres. Known simply as “the Three Cities,” they housed the workshops where wool was processed into cloth and the homes of the great merchants and guilds. The woolworker and merchant guilds became very powerful and came to dominate politics in the trading cities.

30,000 The number of workers involved in Florence's cloth industry in the 1330s, according to the Florentine chronicler Villani, out of an estimated population of just 100,000.

Bruges: canals for pleasure and trade

Trade transformed small towns, making merchants and artisans wealthy; this image from about 1520 shows Bruges at the height of its wealth and power. Bruges' North Sea port and canals formed vital arteries for trade, linking the town to England, Genoa, and other trading centers.

Flanders imported most of its raw materials, including wool to make cloth, from England. Flanders itself grew corn and rye, which it exported, and plants to make dye for the cloth manufacturers. However, trade was often damaged by regulations brought in by English kings, who sought to encourage home-grown cloth production. From 1277, Flanders began to look elsewhere and started

to trade more extensively with Genoa and other Italian cities.



Towers of San Gimignano
These towers in Tuscany were not built to protect the town from outsiders, but to defend rival family factions within the town from each other.

AFTER

The great centers of trade shifted away from Flanders and Italy during the 16th century.

ITALIAN CITY-STATES

A dispute between the French and Spanish over the **Duchy of Milan** turned Italy into a battlefield, damaging Italian trade. By 1527, the Holy Roman Emperor Charles V captured Rome and the city was sacked by his mercenaries, the Landsknechts.

After the **discovery of America**, the focus of trade shifted from the Mediterranean to the Atlantic. Countries such as England, Portugal, and Spain benefited, while Italian trade declined.

NORTHERN EUROPE

Flemish trade suffered as **English manufacturers** began to process their own wool, helped by Flemish immigrants. The **Hanseatic League**, a trading alliance of northern European towns, began to operate through the Baltic as far as England, providing a great stimulus for the northern economies.



LANDSKNECHT